

## Chapter 25: The Space Between Us

Jenny noticed it first in the small things.

How Austin no longer sat at table seven every time.

How he sometimes stood near the counter instead.

How he started saying her name without waiting for permission to speak it.

It wasn't louder.

It was closer.

And that closeness changed the rhythm of her day in ways she couldn't ignore anymore.

"Jenny," Bao called.

She snapped out of it.

"What?"

"You've been staring at the same plate for thirty seconds."

"I was thinking."

"About him?"

Jenny shot him a look.

"No."

Bao raised an eyebrow.

"You hesitated."

"I didn't."

"You did."

Jenny sighed and wiped the counter harder than necessary.

"Stop making it weird."

"It is weird."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because he wasn't wrong.

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When Austin arrived that day, he didn't sit.

He walked straight to the counter.

Jenny looked up immediately.

"...You're not sitting?"

"I'm not staying long."

That made her pause.

"Why?"

Austin didn't answer right away.

Instead, he watched her work for a moment.

Like he was studying something familiar.

Then—

"I have a meeting," he said.

Jenny nodded slowly.

"Okay."

But something in her tone changed without permission.

She hated that.

Austin noticed.

Of course he did.

"You don't like that," he said.

"I don't care," she replied too quickly.

A faint pause.

Then softly—

"You do."

Jenny frowned.

"I said I don't."

Austin leaned slightly against the counter.

"Jenny."

Just her name.

Nothing else.

But it made her stop.

That was becoming a problem.

She looked at him.

"What?"

He studied her carefully.

"I'm going away for a few days."

That landed differently than before.

Not dramatic.

Not shocking.

Just... heavy.

Jenny blinked.

"...Okay."

A pause.

"That's it?" he asked.

"What do you want me to say?"

"I don't know."

That honesty again.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You always leave," she said lightly.

"This is different."

"Is it?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"Yes."

That made her pause.

"How?"

A beat.

Then quietly—

"Because this time I'm not leaving emotionally."

Jenny frowned.

"...What does that even mean?"

Austin looked at her for a moment.

Then said,

"I'm still here. Even when I'm not."

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

She didn't like how much that affected her.

So she deflected.

"That sounds dramatic."

"It's not."

"It is."

He almost smiled.

Almost.

But it faded quickly.

"I just wanted you to know," he said.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Why?"

"Because I don't want you thinking this is distance."

She looked at him.

"And what is it?"

A pause.

Then—

"Maintenance."

That made her blink.

"...Maintenance?"

Austin nodded.

"Yes."

"For what?"

"For us."

The word landed too naturally in his sentence.

Us.

Jenny didn't correct him.

She should have.

But she didn't.

Instead she looked away first.

Of course she did.

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When he left later that afternoon, he didn't linger like before.

No long stares.

No dramatic pauses.

Just a simple nod.

A quiet,

"I'll be back."

And then he was gone.

Jenny stood at the counter long after the door closed.

Bao leaned beside her.

"He's getting confident."

Jenny didn't answer.

"That wasn't a question," Bao added.

"I know."

"You're not scared."

Jenny finally looked at him.

"I didn't say that."

"But you're not stopping him either."

That hit harder than expected.

Jenny turned away.

"I have work."

Bao didn't follow.

But his voice did.

"That's not an answer, Jenny."

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That night, Jenny walked home alone.

But it didn't feel like before.

Because for the first time...

She wasn't wondering where he was.

She was wondering when he would come back.

And worse than that...

She already knew he would.